

Appearance Day at Rādhā-kuṇḍa

A personal pilgrim observance for remembering Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī

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The day

The living Gauḍīya calendar tradition observes Śrīla Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī's appearance on Māgha śukla pañcamī — Vasanta-pañcamī. The same tithi is also associated in Gauḍīya calendars with the appearances of Viṣṇupriyā Devī, Puṇḍarīka Vidyānidhi and Raghunandana Ṭhākura.

Source-critical note: this tithi is strong as living Gauḍīya observance, but the project has not yet recovered an early sixteenth-century biographical witness fixing Raghunātha's appearance to this lunar day. Preserve the distinction between living liturgical tradition and earliest historical documentation.

Working pilgrimage date: the current Vṛndāvana Vaiṣṇava calendar places Māgha śukla pañcamī on Thursday, 11 February 2027. Re-check the local Vraja pañjikā shortly before the pilgrimage because tithi observance follows the local lunar calendar, not a permanently fixed Gregorian date.

No special Raghunātha-specific fast is assumed in this guide. Follow the vrata or prasāda practice of your guru-lineage and the local Vaiṣṇava program rather than inventing an austerity in imitation of Raghunātha.

What the day is for

The aim is not to spend the day admiring how little Raghunātha ate.

His life is better remembered as a chain of mercy: Haridāsa's association, Nityānanda's grace at Pānihāṭi, Mahāprabhu's acceptance, Svarūpa's shelter, the Govardhana-śilā and guñjā-mālā, Rūpa and Sanātana refusing his death, and finally his life of Rādhā-dāsyā at Rādhā-kuṇḍa.

On his appearance day, let the physical places around Rādhā-kuṇḍa become memory-points for that chain.

A simple observance for the day

1. Begin quietly before the crowds and programs take over the day. Chant your normal morning japa. Add no heroic quota simply because it is Raghunātha's appearance day. The first offering is steadiness, not imitation.
2. At the beginning of the day, read a short life-summary rather than the whole eighteen-chapter biography. A good sequence is RDGB-01 or its childhood section, RDGB-04 on Pānihāṭi, RDGB-06 on Svarūpera Raghu, RDGB-08 on the Govardhana-śilā and guñjā-mālā, RDGB-12 on Rūpa and Sanātana, and RDGB-18 at the samādhi.
3. Go to Raghunātha's bhajana-kuṭīra and samādhi with no hurry. If a local kīrtana, kathā, pūjā, Vaiṣṇava-sevā or mahāprasāda program is taking place, allow the living observance to take precedence over your private schedule.
4. At the kuṭīra, remember Purī. This is the place to read Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa 11, where Raghunātha himself remembers Mahāprabhu rescuing him from great wealth, placing him with Svarūpa, and giving the guñjā garland and Govardhana-śilā.

*mahā-sampad-dāvād api patitam uddhṛtya kṛpayā
svarūpe yaḥ svīye kujanam api mām nyasya muditaḥ |
uro-guñjā-hāraṁ priyam api ca govardhana-śilām
dadau me gaurāṅgo hṛdaya udayan mām madayati || 11 ||*

“By mercy He lifted even me, fallen into the forest fire of immense wealth; joyfully He placed this unworthy person with His own Svarūpa, and He gave me the dear guñjā garland from His chest and the beloved Govardhana-śilā. May that Gaurāṅga rise within my heart and intoxicate me.”

5. At the samādhi, do not begin with a list of austerities. Begin with belonging. Read Vilāpa-kusumāñjali 96–97 slowly.

*tavaivāsmi tavaivāsmi
na jīvāmi tvayā vinā |
iti vijñāya devi tvam
naya mām caraṇāntike || 96 ||*

*sva-kuṇḍam tava lolākṣi
sa-priyāyāḥ sadāspadam |
atraiva mama saṁvāsa
ihaiva mama saṁsthitih || 97 ||*

“I am Yours. I am Yours. I cannot live without You. Knowing this, O Devī, please bring me near Your feet. O restless-eyed one, Your own kuṇḍa is the eternal abode of You together with Your beloved. Here alone shall be my residence; here alone shall be my abiding place.”

6. Then sit silently for a few minutes. A useful personal prayer is simple: ask for attachment to the holy name, shelter in genuine Vaiṣṇava relationship, freedom from self-display, and a particle of Raghunātha’s longing for service.
7. Approach Rādhā-kuṇḍa itself as the place Raghunātha called his shelter. Use the bathing and etiquette guidance already established in RKPG-01 rather than reproducing it here. If you take snāna, do so according to your lineage, health, local conditions and the established guide.
8. At the bank of Rādhā-kuṇḍa, read Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka 5. It tells you what the kuṇḍa meant to Raghunātha: service to the kuṇḍa culminates in the flower of service to his Mistress.

*api jana iha kaścid yasya sevā-prasādaiḥ
praṇaya-sura-latā syāt tasya goṣṭhendra-sūnoḥ |
sapadi kila mad-īśā-dāsya-puṣpa-prasasyā
tad ati-surabhi rādhā-kuṇḍam evāśrayo me || 5 ||*

“By the grace of serving this kuṇḍa, the celestial vine of love for the son of the lord of Vraja may arise and immediately become glorious with the flower of service to my Mistress. May that exceedingly fragrant Rādhā-kuṇḍa alone be my shelter.”

9. If you go to Girirāja the same day, carry one verse rather than a long reading list. Govardhana-vāsa-prārthanā-daśaka 10 is especially fitting because Raghunātha explicitly remembers that Śacīnandana entrusted him to Govardhana.

*nirupadhi-karuṇena śrī-śacīnandanena
tvayi kapaṭi-śaṭho 'pi tvat-priyenārpito 'smi |
iti khalu mama yogyāyogyatāṁ mām agrhṇan
nija-nikaṭa-nivāsaṁ dehi govardhana tvam ||10||*

“By the causeless mercy of Śrī Śacīnandana I, though deceitful and unfit, have been entrusted to you by one dear to you. Therefore, without considering whether I am qualified or unqualified, O Govardhana, please grant me residence near you.”

10. End the day with Vaiṣṇava association and prasāda if available. Raghunātha’s decisive turning points repeatedly came through other devotees. A solitary observance that ignores the Vaiṣṇavas would miss something central in his life.

A compact reading sequence

Moment	Reading	Why this reading
Morning	RDGB-04 — Pānihāṭi	Grace comes before escape; service to Vaiṣṇavas opens the door.
Late morning	RDGB-06 — Svarūpera Raghu	Mahāprabhu places him under Svarūpa rather than making him spiritually independent.
At bhajana-kuṭīra	RDGB-08 — Govardhana in His Hands	The śilā and guṇjā-mālā connect Purī directly to his Vraja life.
At samādhi	RDGB-12 + RDGB-18	Rūpa and Sanātana refuse his death; the life ends in belonging, not heroic isolation.
At Rādhā-kuṇḍa	Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka 5 and 8	Rādhā-kuṇḍa as shelter, daily līlā and Rādhā-dāsyā.
Evening	RDGB-15 — The Poet of Longing	See what filled the inner world behind the outward vairāgya.

If you want only three prayers

If the day becomes crowded, emotional or physically tiring, do not turn the observance into a checklist. Three short texts are enough:

- Gaurāṅga-stava-kalpavṛkṣa 11 — remember who gave Raghunātha his life of renunciation and service.

- Rādhā-kuṇḍāṣṭaka 5 — remember the goal as mad-īśā-dāsyā, service to Rādhā.
- Vilāpa-kusumāñjali 96–97 — surrender and residence: “I am Yours” and “Here alone shall be my abode.”

What not to imitate

Raghunātha’s severe fasting, minimal sleep and bodily neglect belong to his extraordinary individual life and are not the recommended way to honor his appearance day.

Do not create a new fast, reduce water, skip needed food, stay awake all night, or multiply daṇḍavats beyond your ordinary capacity merely to resemble him.

The safer and more faithful imitation is qualitative: simplicity, humility, nāma, gratitude for Vaiṣṇavas, attention to Mahāprabhu’s mercy, and longing for service.

At the samādhī: a personal meditation

Raghunātha, you were born into wealth but learned that mercy was greater than possession. Nityānanda made you serve the Vaiṣṇavas. Mahāprabhu gave you to Svarūpa. He placed Govardhana and Rādhā’s shelter in your hands. Rūpa and Sanātana would not let grief end your life. At Rādhā-kuṇḍa you turned that rescued life into service, memory, poetry and longing. Please let me remember your life without imitating what I am not qualified to imitate. Give me attachment to the holy name, dependence upon genuine Vaiṣṇavas, and a small desire to serve Śrī Rādhā at the feet of those who are dear to Her.

Practical field notes

- Local program first: if the samādhī or nearby Vaiṣṇava community announces appearance-day kathā, kīrtana, pūjā or prasāda, join respectfully rather than insisting on this private sequence.
- Keep RDGB-A01 on the phone as the short field document; keep RDGB-01–18 available for longer reading when sitting.
- Use RKPG-01 for Rādhā-kuṇḍa snāna, dress, water-contact and etiquette details; do not rely on this appendix as the bathing guide.
- Use RKPG-02 for additional prayers to Rādhā-kuṇḍa, Govardhana and the Divine Couple.
- Do not assume every current structure or marked spot is unchanged from Raghunātha’s lifetime. The samādhī and bhajana-kuṭīra are living sacred-memory sites; precise architectural continuity is a separate historical question.
- For 2027, re-confirm Māgha śukla pañcamī with the local Vraja calendar shortly before travel.